

VYNN SUREN

Sabah, Malaysia

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Profile

Sabah-based civic researcher, public historian, and community communicator with experience working on Sabah history, political and social institutions, land ownership, indigenous governance, and public engagement. Currently pursuing an MA in Civilizational Studies at Universiti Malaysia Sabah, with research focused on the relationship between land ownership, agency, rights, and responsibility in Sabah.

My work combines philosophical and historical research with public communication, community engagement, institutional development, and storytelling. I have worked with Sabah civil-society and cultural organisations, organised and moderated public discussions, developed public history content, engaged diverse stakeholders, and contributed to projects aimed at strengthening public understanding of Sabah's history and civic institutions.

Civic Leadership & Sabah Engagement

The Sabah Society

Sabah, Malaysia

Leadership / Communications / Public History

- Contributed to the development of The Sabah Society as a platform for public knowledge, networking, and discussion concerning Sabah's history, heritage, society, and contemporary affairs.
- Developed and communicated public-history material intended to make Sabah's historical and political development accessible to wider audiences.
- Organised and supported public talks, lectures, discussions, and community events involving historians, academics, cultural practitioners, civil-society actors, and members of the public.
- Worked on organisational communications, social media, newsletters, website content, publications, event promotion, and audience development.
- Supported membership development, stakeholder engagement, institutional partnerships, fundraising, and efforts to position the Society as a hub for Sabah expertise and civic knowledge.
- Developed public-facing initiatives including historical storytelling and "This Day in Sabah History" content to encourage greater public engagement with Sabah's historical memory.

Sabah Literary Circle

Sabah, Malaysia

Secretary

- Support the development of a Sabah-based literary and cultural organisation concerned with Sabah's intellectual, historical, and cultural life.
- Contribute to organisational planning, committee coordination, institutional correspondence, meetings, and programme development.
- Engage with cultural institutions, historians, writers, academics, libraries, museums, and public figures to strengthen Sabah's literary and intellectual networks.
- Participate in discussions concerning institutional development, funding, cultural programming, and the preservation and dissemination of Sabah's intellectual heritage.

Research on Land, Governance & Responsibility

Universiti Malaysia Sabah (UMS)

Sabah, Malaysia

MA Civilizational Studies — Researcher

Thesis: "Ownership and Responsibility: A Philosophical Study of Land, Agency, and Normative Attribution in Sabah"

- Investigate how responsibility is attributed to owners and other actors in relation to land, and what rights and obligations are constituted by land ownership.

- Examine the relationship between formal land law, ownership, agency, responsibility, and the allocation of rights and duties in Sabah.
- Study the historical development of land tenure and the interaction between formal legal institutions and customary systems of land governance.
- Engage with questions concerning indigenous governance, customary tenure, community authority, legal recognition, and the distribution of responsibility over land.
- Develop research methods combining philosophical analysis, legal and historical research, archival investigation, and qualitative engagement with relevant stakeholders and communities.

Civic significance: This research addresses a practical problem in Sabah's governance: how different systems of authority determine who has rights over land, who bears obligations toward it, and who can legitimately be held responsible for decisions affecting land and communities.

Public History, Storytelling & Communication

- Develop public-facing narratives that connect Sabah's historical development with contemporary questions of identity, governance, institutions, and citizenship.
- Translate complex historical, philosophical, and political material into accessible formats for public audiences through articles, social media, talks, newsletters, video, and digital storytelling.
- Produce and coordinate communications across Facebook, Instagram, X, WhatsApp, websites, email newsletters, and YouTube.
- Host and moderate public events and Q&A sessions, including discussions involving politically sensitive subjects and competing perspectives.
- Work with historians, academics, cultural practitioners, community leaders, civil-society organisations, and members of the public to communicate Sabah's history and contemporary issues.

Selected Professional Experience

Effective Altruism Malaysia

Malaysia

Communications Manager

- Developed national outreach and communications strategies for a volunteer-driven civic and ideas-oriented organisation.
- Led digital storytelling, educational campaigns, public communication, and audience outreach.
- Coordinated communications across organisational and international networks and translated complex ideas into accessible public-facing material.

Malaysian Philosophical Society

Malaysia

Content Curator

- Developed and curated accessible philosophical content for public audiences.
- Contributed to public engagement with philosophical questions, reasoning, ethics, society, and political life.

Education

Universiti Malaysia Sabah (UMS)

Sabah, Malaysia

MA Civilizational Studies

Current

- Research focus: land ownership, agency, responsibility, rights, obligations, customary governance, and Sabah's legal and political institutions.

University of York

United Kingdom

BSc Biomedical Science

2017–2021

Core Skills

Civic Engagement: Stakeholder engagement, community outreach, public dialogue, event facilitation, institutional networking

Research: Historical research, archival research, qualitative research, philosophical analysis, legal and institutional analysis

Communication: Public speaking, moderation, storytelling, writing, digital communications, public-history communication, politically sensitive communication

Digital: Social media management, website content, newsletters, Canva, video and multimedia production, online community management

Languages: English; Malay

References

Available upon request.